

On Theology's Concept of Nature

with Special Reference to

Malebranche: *De la recherche de la vérité*

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Between theology and natural science there is no understanding; theology's concept of nature is not natural, and natural science's is not theological.

Even by merely confining oneself to a factual juxtaposition of those natural events in whose interpretation natural science most decidedly contradicts theology, it would be easy to make the disagreement between the two sciences conspicuous. Touch whichever dogma, whichever theological presupposition one will; insofar as there can in any way be a question of a real, corresponding natural relation, natural science, by virtue of the investigation of the facts, must reject the theological explanation.

Is it the creation in six days: natural science proves that for the formation of the earth alone a period of more than 6×6 million years must have elapsed.

Is it the dogma of Paradise and the Fall: natural science proves that there was corruptibility, pain, and death in the world long before the first human beings came to be.

Is the talk of the Flood and Noah's Ark: natural science proves that "the Flood" is a natural local catastrophe, and that the animals could not possibly have been saved in Noah's Ark, since the beasts of prey would in a few days have devoured the other animals, and thereafter have died of hunger.

Thus one could go on, and still not reach the goal. Even if the juxtaposition were carried through ever so completely, the grounds and counter-grounds from both sides

sought out and weighed ever so carefully, it would nevertheless along this path hardly be possible to arrive at any decisive result.

To be sure, natural science, with respect to the main points of the matter, is on the whole in agreement with itself, just as theology too must on the whole be said to follow a direction answering to its own peculiar endeavours; but one may not on that account suppose that either of the two sciences would at a given time be wholly and entirely in agreement with itself in the interpretation of particulars.

Natural science is, as they say, in becoming; this becoming — under which, as regards particulars, it continually corrects itself, secures its method, purifies and broadens its foundation — is precisely characteristic of its luxuriant growth, its restless, imposing progress.

Theology, then, is in its own way also in becoming — a becoming, namely, under which its ever-increasing lack of principle and the inward discord of its members point more or less toward the weakness of old age and impending dissolution¹.

If both sciences are now thus each in its own becoming, then it would surely help but little for anyone to begin afresh either to weigh the grounds for and against “the Flood,” or to debate the problem of “Noah’s Ark,” or, in other words, to set natural science’s conception of particular phenomena against theology’s particular dogmas.

If an understanding between theology and natural science is to be thought possible, it must presumably begin with the two sciences coming to agreement in the determination of that concept which, for the scientific reality of both, is a decisive fundamental concept, namely the concept: *nature*.

By such a determination of the concept one cannot here first of all think of some definition in general; for with formal definitions little is accomplished in natural science. The task is to indicate the point of view under which the essence of nature can be seen in the purest, truest scientific light.

Relying on the testimony of the senses and the validity of thought, natural science begins by taking existing things as they are given, then advances by exact examination from the known to the as-yet-unknown, and everywhere confines itself to seeing nature in nature’s light.

Theology, on the other hand, chooses for itself a higher point of departure. Beginning with the Creator, it passes through creation over to the creature, and so comes, by its

¹Lest it should seem to some reader less acquainted with the discussions belonging here as though this assertion were thrown out without any foundation, I must for the present refer to my work *Evangelitroen og Theologien*. I may do so with all the more right, since no theologian yet, so far as is known to me, has found himself moved to show the groundlessness of the view set forth in the said work.

own opinion, to behold nature as God's work in God's light.

If it now really is the case that there truly exists a science able to present nature in God's light, and if this science is theology: then indeed the theological concept of nature, whatever may be said for or against the interpretation of any single phenomenon, is undeniably the highest norm by which empirical science, in its judgment of the essence of nature, has to direct itself.

But should it, on the other hand, prove scientifically demonstrable that there neither is nor can be a science able in any way, in any degree, to elucidate the natural by means of the supernatural: might we not then conclude from this that the theological doctrine of creation, with its corresponding explanation of nature, had best be assigned a place of its own outside of science?

As a representative of the theological conception of the essence of nature, we choose, for the clarification of the matter, a keen thinker, the author of the work *De la Recherche de la Vérité*², the noble Malebranche.

That Malebranche is a Catholic, and that his Cartesian natural philosophy has long since been antiquated, is of no significance in this connection.

Here, as regards the dogmas, there is only one dogma on which it essentially depends; it is the dogma of creation. Here, as regards natural science, there is only one task on which attention is fixed; it is the task of recognizing nature as God's work, of beholding all things in God.

Inwardly convinced that this great task can be solved, M. is so far from withdrawing into the mysterious, and concealing poverty of thought in aesthetically nebulous speculations, that he rather calls for beginning with the particular, the distinct, the easily comprehensible, and in many places speaks a language such that one would believe it was not one of the Fathers of the Oratory speaking of God's omnipotence, but one of today's naturalists dismissing philosophical mysticism³.

²Paris MDCLXXVIII.

³Jfr. t. Ex. De l. Recherch. S. 394. Combien de gens rejettent la Philosophie de M. Descartes par cette plaisante raison que les principes en sont trop simples et trop faciles. Il n'y a point de termes obscurs et mystérieux dans cette Philosophie: des femmes et des personnes qui ne savent ni grec ni latin, sont capables de l'apprendre: il faut donc que soit peu de chose, et il n'est pas juste que de grands génies s'y appliquent. Ils s'imaginent que des principes si clairs et si simples ne sont pas assez féconds, pour expliquer les effets de la nature qu'ils supposent obscure et embarrassée. ... Ils aiment donc mieux expliquer des effets, dont ils ne comprennent point la cause, par des principes qu'ils ne conçoivent point, et qu'il est absolument impossible de concevoir, que par des principes simples et intelligibles tout-ensemble. Car ces Philosophes expliquent des choses obscures par des principes qui ne sont pas seulement obscurs, mais entièrement incompréhensibles.

"It is" — so thinks Malebranche — "error that is the cause of man's misery; it is therefore necessary that it be combated with all one's powers. One must not imagine that it is so troublesome to seek the truth. One need only open one's eyes, be attentive, and follow a few rules which we shall give in what follows. For it is, after all, sharp thinking that brings light and discovers the truth."

"Although our senses are corrupted by sin, it is nevertheless not really the senses, but our freedom, that is the cause of our errors."

"For since we are composed of mind and body (Etant composez d'un esprit et d'un corps), we have two kinds of goods to seek, the mind's and the body's. We have then also two ways in which we can know whether something is good or evil. We can know a good either by a clear insight or by an obscure sensation (un sentiment confus). I recognize by reason that justice is lovable; I also know by taste that this or that fruit is good. The beauty of justice cannot be sensed (ne se sent pas), the goodness of the fruit cannot be thought (ne se connoit pas). The goods of the body therefore do not deserve that a mind, which God has created only for himself, should scrutinize them; it is therefore necessary that the mind, without further examination (examen), be able to know such goods by the short, indubitable test of sensation⁴."

"If the mind saw in bodies only what is really in them, then it could not love them, and could not make use of them without much reluctance; it is therefore necessary that they seem agreeable, in that they occasion feelings that do not pertain to their essence."

"But it is not so with God, who alone is the mind's true good; for him it is not enough to be loved with the blind love of instinct; he wills to be loved with an enlightened, clear, and resolved love (d'un amour éclairé et d'un amour déchoix)."

"To understand this rightly, one must know that there is a very considerable difference between the way in which the Author of Nature (l'Auteur de la Nature) moves matter, and the way in which he without ceasing moves the mind toward the good in general (vers le bien en general). For matter is without any activity, without power to arrest its motion or determine its direction."

"It is otherwise with the will; of it one can nevertheless in a certain sense (en un sens) say that it is active, and that it has in itself the power to take up the impression (impression) God gives it⁵ in various ways, and thereby to occasion all the disorder (dérèglement) that shows itself in the inclinations, and all the miseries that are consequences

⁴S. 18. Les pierres ne sont pas propres à la nourriture, la preuve en est convaincante, et le seul goût en a fait tomber d'accord tous les hommes.

⁵S. 5. car quoi qu' elle ne puisse pas arrêter cette impression, elle peut en un sens la détourner du côté qu'il lui plaît...

of sin.”

“Even if the will is not free in the sense that it should have the power to will and not to will, it is nevertheless able to drive us forward toward the good in general⁶.”

“Since the will always directs itself according to the representation of the good, and we cannot possibly will that which at the same moment we must regard as an essential evil, there must be the most intimate connection between cognition and will, between the true and the good⁷.”

“The senses and passions (les sens et les passions) do not have their origin from sin, but the power with which they tyrannize sinners does. This power is not so much a disturbance on the side of the senses as a confusion in man’s mind and will.”

“Adam, in his state of innocence, had the same senses as we, but was the unconditional master of the impressions of joy and pain that they awakened in his body. Only when he voluntarily turned away from the countenance of God, as it were to sate his mind with the beauty and anticipated sweetness of the forbidden fruit, did his senses and passions rebel against him, and make him, like us, a slave of all sensuous things.”

“Our senses are not so corrupted as one imagines; but it is the innermost of our soul, it is our freedom, that is corrupted. It is not our senses that deceive us; it is our will that deceives us by its rash judgments.”

“When one, for example, sees light, then it is quite certain that one sees light; when one feels warmth, one does not deceive oneself in believing that one feels it — be it before or after the Fall.”

“But one deceives oneself when one assumes (quand on juge) that the warmth one feels is outside the soul that feels it. It is a rash judgment, resting on the misuse of freedom. Therefore we ought carefully to observe the rule never to judge by the senses what things are in themselves; for the senses are in reality not given that we should know the truth of things in themselves, but only to preserve our body (pour la conservation de notre corps).”

“The ground of error also does not lie in the limitation of our understanding; for the understanding is indeed limited, but it is nevertheless the will that guides our power of judgment⁸. It therefore becomes a task of the will to work its way out of the illusion and seek the truth. But to seek the truth is in all things to seek God.”

⁶S. 5. ... par ce mot de *Volonté*, je prétens ici désigner l’impression ou le mouvement naturel, qui nous porte vers le bien indéterminé et en général: et par celui de *Liberté*, je n’entens autre chose que la force qu’ a l’esprit de détourner cette impression vers les objets, qui nous plaisent.

⁷S. 6. C’est à-peu-près la même chose de la connoissance de la vérité que de l’amour du bien.

⁸S. 6 ... nous sommes aussi libres dans nos faux jugemens, que dans nos amours déreglez...

“Truth is known by its clarity, by its self-evidence⁹; it must therefore be impressed upon us that we never grant anything before it is so evident to us that we are as it were compelled by the inner, earnest correction of our reason (jusqu’à ce que nous y soyons comme forcez par des reproches intérieures de notre raison¹⁰).”

After thus having pointed out the cause of error, and having besides (in the first and second Books) treated in detail the errors occasioned by the senses and the imagination, the author passes over (in the third Book) to treat of the essence of the mind: *De l’entendement ou de l’esprit pur*.

The general relation between mind and matter has already, in the first Book, been conceived in the following way:

“Just as matter, the extended, has a twofold capacity — a capacity to receive different form, and a capacity to be moved — so too the human mind has two faculties, *the understanding* (l’entendement), by which we apprehend different ideas, that is: bring different things to consciousness, and *the will* (la volonté), the capacity for manifold inclinations, or the willing of different things.”

This juxtaposition of the material and the mental, whereby apparent points of resemblance are brought out, must not, however, be understood as though a natural kinship between mind and matter were here presupposed. On the contrary! It is impressed throughout the whole investigation, from first to last, that the two substances are as heterogeneous as possible.

Although different faculties are ascribed to them, they nevertheless have no active faculties¹¹. The concept “faculty” must here, for the mind as well as for matter, be taken in so passive a sense that it does not at all express a capacity for reciprocal activity, but only a possibility of being acted upon by God¹².

“The essence of the mind,” it now says (third Book), “consists in thinking alone, just as that of matter in extension alone. It is in accordance with the different modifications of thinking that the mind is now willing, now representing, or has several other peculiar

⁹S. 9. Car la vérité ne se trouve presque jamais qu’ avec l’évidence, et l’évidence ne consiste que dans la vûe claire et distincte de toutes les parties et de tous les rapports de l’objet, qui sont nécessaires pour porter un jugement assuré.

¹⁰S. 1–2. L’exactitude de l’esprit n’a presque rien de pénible: ce n’est point une servitude comme l’imagination la représente; et si nous y trouvons d’abord quelque difficulté, nous en recevons bientôt des satisfactions qui nous récompensent bien de nos peines; car enfin il n’y a qu’elle qui produise la lumière, et qui découvre la vérité.

¹¹S. 4. C’est pour nous accommoder à la manière ordinaire de parler, que nous dirons dans la suite, que les sens sentent...

¹²S. 5. De même que l’Auteur de la Nature est la cause universelle de tous les mouvemens, qui se trouvent dans la matière; c’est aussi lui qui est la cause générale de toutes les inclinations naturelles qui se trouvent dans les esprits...

forms.”

“It likewise depends on different modifications, namely of extension, that matter is now water, now wood, now fire, or has an infinity of other such forms¹³.”

Since now the essence of the mind is placed in thought, it might indeed seem as though on the whole too strong an emphasis were here laid on the will; but M. expressly remarks that the faculty of willing is nevertheless inseparable from the mind, although it does not constitute its essence, just as the faculty of being moved is inseparable from matter, although it likewise does not constitute matter's essence.

“Even if thinking is the essence of the mind, we may nevertheless by no means conclude from this that the thinking mind should be able of itself to know all the modifications whose possibility it contains¹⁴.”

“When our soul here below receives only very few modifications, it is because it is bound to a body and dependent on it.”

“The matter of which our body is composed is able to receive only very few modifications, as long as we live. This matter cannot dissolve into earth, into vapour, until after our death. During our lifetime it cannot become air, fire, diamond, metal; it cannot become round, square, triangular: it must be flesh, and have a human figure, in order that our soul may be united with it.”

“It is the same with the soul. It is necessary that it have sensations of warmth, of cold, of colour, of light, of tones, of smell, of taste, and many other modifications. These sensations teach it precisely to preserve its machine (*l'appliquent à la conservation de sa machine*¹⁵).”

“Let one beware of dispersing the mind by wanting to explain things that are far too intricate. For the human mind is subject to errors, not only because it is not infinite,

¹³S. 171. Je ne croi pas aussi qu'il soit possible de concevoir un esprit qui ne pense point, quoi qu'il soit fort facile d'en concevoir un qui ne sente point, qui n'imagine point, et même qui ne veuille point: de même qu'il n'est pas possible de concevoir une matière, qui ne soit pas étendue quoi qu'il soit assez facile d'en concevoir une, qui ne soit ni terre, ni métal ni quarrée ni ronde et qui même ne soit point en mouvement. Il faut conclure de là, que comme il se peut faire qu'il y ait de la matière, qui ne soit ni terre ni métal, ni quarrée ni ronde ni même en mouvement: il se peut faire aussi qu'un esprit ne sente ni chaud ni froid, ni joie, ni tristesse, n'imagine rien, et même ne veuille rien; de sorte que toutes ces modifications ne lui sont point essentielles. *La pensée toute seule est donc l'essence de l'esprit, ainsi que l'étendue toute seule est l'essence de la matière.*

¹⁴S. 173. Un simple morceau de cire est donc capable d'un nombre infini, ou plutôt d'un nombre infiniment infini de différentes modifications, que nul esprit ne peut comprendre. Quelle raison donc de s'imaginer que l'âme qui est beaucoup plus noble que le corps, ne soit capable que des seules modifications qu'elle a déjà reçues.

¹⁵Elles l'agitent, et l'effraient dès que le moindre ressort se débande, ou se rompt, et ainsi il faut que l'âme y soit sujette, tant que son corps sera sujet à la corruption. Mais lorsqu'il sera revêtu de l'immortalité, et que nous ne craignons plus la dissolution de ses parties, il est raisonnable de croire qu'elle ne sera plus touchée de ces sensations incommodes que nous sentons malgré nous; mais d'une infinité d'autres toutes différentes, dont nous n'avons maintenant aucune idée.

but also because it does not have enough perseverance to dwell on each single object so long, until it has been in every respect completely and exactly investigated.”

“The objects with which the mind occupies itself can be divided into two classes: they are either in the soul or outside it.”

“Those that are in the soul are its own thoughts, by which are in general understood all the things (*toutes les choses!*) that cannot be in the soul without its becoming aware of them, such as: its own sensations, its imaginations, pure concepts and representations, even its passions (*ses passions mêmes*) and natural inclinations.”

As regards these objects, the soul can indeed know them without needing an intermediary; for they are nothing other than the soul itself, modified in this or that way (*d'une telle ou telle façon*); but *how does the soul come to the knowledge of the objects that are outside the soul?*

That is a chief question.

“We see the sun, the stars, an infinite multitude of objects outside us; yet it is not probable that the soul goes out of the body, that it, so to speak, takes a stroll through the heavens in order there to behold all these objects. Nor, then, does it see them by themselves. The mind's immediate object, when it sees the sun, is not the sun itself, but a something that is intimately united with our soul, and it is this that I call the idea” (S. 188. *De la nature des idées*).

The characteristic feature of M.'s doctrine of ideas is now a direct consequence of the peculiar way in which he, in relation to the philosophical standpoint of the time, explains to himself the knowledge of external objects.

“Material objects cannot possibly be apprehended by themselves; they are apprehended only by the ideas corresponding to them in the soul: whence then come these ideas?”¹⁶

Toward an answer to this question M. makes his way through a critique of the theories diverging from his own view.

“The Peripatetics' opinion, that external objects should send us their images (*des espèces, qui leur ressemblent*), and that these should then, through the outer senses, be brought to the common sense (*au sens commun*), is unreasonable; these impression-images (*especes impresses*) would then themselves have to be little bodies¹⁷, and these

¹⁶S. 190. Nous assurons donc qu'il est absolument nécessaire, que les idées, que nous avons des corps, et de tous les autres objets, que nous n'appersons point par eux mêmes, viennent de ces mêmes corps ou de ces objets: ou bien que nôtre âme ait la puissance de produire ces idées: ou que Dieu les ait produites avec elle en la créant, ou qu'il les produise toutes les fois qu'on pense à quelque objet: ou que l'âme ait en elle-même toutes les perfections qu'elle voit dans ces corps: ou enfin qu'elle soit unie avec un être tout parfait, et qui renferme généralement toutes les perfections des êtres créés.

¹⁷S. 191. Tous les objets, comme le Soleil, les Etoiles, et tous ceux qui sont proche de nos yeux, ne peuvent pas envoyer des especes, qui soient d'autre nature qu'eux ... c'est pourquoi les Philosophes disent

bodies, with which space would be filled, would then, owing to the impenetrability of matter, have to crush and collide with one another, some going to one side, others to another, and thus could not make the objects visible.”

The opinion of those who assume that the ideas of objects are created with us, so that God does not need at each moment to awaken them in the soul when we have need of them, is refuted by the following consideration:

“We have, even as regards simple figures, an infinite multitude of ideas. Ellipses, triangles, polygons, and the like can, with respect to proportions of magnitude, be imagined in innumerable ways¹⁸. It is then highly improbable that God should have created such a swarm of ideas in and with the human mind. But suppose that we did have such a store of co-created ideas (*un magasin de toutes les idées*), it still remains wholly inexplicable how we come to apply the right idea when the corresponding object presents itself. We see, for example, the sun. The image that the sun imprints in the brain has, as already shown, no resemblance to the idea we form of the sun; nor does the soul notice the least thing of the impression the sun makes either on the ground of the eye or in the brain: it is therefore impossible to explain how, among the innumerable ideas, we come precisely to choose the idea of the sun when we see the sun.” “Those who maintain that our souls themselves have the faculty of being able to form ideas corresponding to the objects about which we would think, although the impressions coming from these objects are not images resembling the objects, have either far too poor conceptions of ideas or far too lofty thoughts of the human mind¹⁹.”

“Such an imagining of the soul’s perfection is presumptuous. God alone can in himself behold and know all things, since he is the Creator of all things. ‘Say not that you have the light in yourselves,’ says St. Augustine, ‘for God alone has the light in himself.’”

“There then remains only one view as the sole rational one (*qui paroît seule conforme à la raison*), namely, that minds have all their thoughts from God.”

“To grasp this rightly, we must first recall that God necessarily must have the ideas of all created things in himself, since otherwise he could not produce them; next, that God, by virtue of his omnipresence, is so intimately united with our souls that one could

ordinairement, que ces especes sont grossieres et matérielles, à la différence des especes *expresses*: (especes matérielles et sensibles, qui sont rendues intelligibles par l’intellect agent ou agissant, et sont propres pour être reçues dans l’intellect patient S. 190) qui sont spiritualisées.

¹⁸S. 196. L’esprit voit donc toutes ces choses: il en a des idées. Il est sûr que ces idées ne lui manqueront jamais, quand il emploieroit des siècles infinis à la considération même d’une seule figure.

¹⁹S. 193. En effet le monde intelligible doit être plus parfait que le monde matériel et terrestre... Ainsi, quand on assure, que les hommes ont la puissance de se former les idées telles qu’il leur plaît, on se met fort en danger d’assurer que les hommes ont la puissance de faire des êtres plus nobles et plus parfaits que le monde que Dieu a créé. On ne fait pas cependant réflexion à cela, parce qu’on s’imagine, qu’une idée n’est rien, à cause qu’elle ne se fait point sentir ...

even say that he is the place of minds ((qu'il est le lieu des esprits), just as one says of space that it is the place of bodies."

"Under these presuppositions it is therefore certain that the mind can see what it is in God that presents created things, since it is so spiritual, so intelligible, so present to the mind. The mind can then see in God God's work, so truly as God wills to reveal it to it." Thus M. comes to set up the principle so indispensable for theology, namely, that we behold all things in God:

Que nous voyons toutes choses en Dieu.

This fundamental proposition must not, however, be misunderstood as though the meaning were that we limited human beings, by seeing things in God, can now also see through God's essence²⁰. Far from it! How should the imperfect be able to grasp the perfect?

"One more reason for assuming that we see all things because God wills it is also this, that we thereby recognize our infinite dependence on God; for of ourselves we know nothing. Non sumus sufficientes cogitare aliquid a nobis, tanquam ex nobis, sed sufficientia nostra a Deo est. 2 Cor. 3, 5."

"It is God himself who enlightens the philosophers in those cognitions which these ungrateful people call natural, although they come to them from heaven. Deus enim illis manifestavit. Rom. 1, 19. It is he who is the mind's true light: Pater luminum. Jac. 1, 17. It is he who teaches men science: Qui docet hominem scientiam. Psalm. 94, 10. In a word: it is the true light which enlightens all those who come into this world: lux vera, quæ illuminat omnem hominem venientem in hunc mundum. Joh. 1, 9."

No one will be able to mistake that this is all theological, truly theological.

These features of a doctrine of knowledge untenable in itself can, however, in this connection interest us only insofar as they furnish the presuppositions for a corresponding view of nature, and thereby make evident what lies in theology's concept of nature, when the consequences contained in it are set forth as clearly, as many-sidedly, as unreservedly, as in Malebranche.

If God's revelation, continuing itself in the thinking minds, is the sole true source of knowledge, then it presumably follows of itself that the essence of things depends solely on the divine will, that nothing in nature has force and power to act of itself, but that it must be God, God alone, who works all in all things.

²⁰S. 200. Mais il faut bien remarquer, qu'on ne peut pas conclure que les esprits voyent l'essence de Dieu, de ce qu'ils voyent toutes choses en Dieu de cette manière. Parce que ce qu'ils voyent est très-imparfait, et que Dieu est très-parfait.

"Aristotle²¹ and the philosophers who follow his banner miss the truth and walk in darkness. Relying on sense-impressions, they give us only empty words and confused representations of things."

"All the categories (termes) that designate only sensuous representations are ambiguous — ambiguous, be it noted, through error and ignorance, and thus in turn the cause of an infinite multitude of errors."

"The word 'Ram,' for example, is ambiguous; it means a ruminant animal; it also means a constellation which the sun enters in spring. By such an expression, to be sure, no one is so easily deceived; for one would have to be an astrologer in the extreme to imagine that there could here be any real connection between Ram and Ram. But as regards the categories of sensuousness otherwise, one is easily deceived; for there is almost no one who notices that they are one and all ambiguous."

"When, for example, the philosophers say: fire is hot; the plant is green, sugar sweet, and so on, they understand it like children and everyday people, as though it were the fire that contained the heat they feel, the plant the colour they think they see, and the sugar the sweetness they taste when they eat it; and so with all things we see or sense. They do not say two words without saying something false: all that they say about this matter is obscure and confused."

This is then proved on various grounds:

"First, human beings are highly at variance about the sensuous impressions: what one finds sweet, another finds bitter; what one finds warm, another finds cold."

"Second, the most diverse objects can make the same sense-impression. Gypsum, snow, sugar, salt, and so on give the same sensation of colour: nevertheless the whiteness of these things is very different, if one will otherwise judge by something other than mere sensation. When one therefore says: the flour is white, one says nothing definite."

"Third, the corporeal properties that cause the most different sense-impressions are now and then almost the same, and, conversely, those that produce roughly the same impression are often very different. The qualities sweetness and bitterness are almost not different, but the sensations of sweetness and bitterness are essentially different. The motions (mouvements) that cause pain and tickling differ only by a more and a less, but the feelings of tickling and pain are essentially different."

"Another series of ambiguous expressions is drawn from logic, by whose general

²¹S. 383. Car les termes ordinaires à ce Philosophe ne peuvent servir qu'à exprimer confusément aux sens et à l'imagination les sentimens confus que l'on a des choses sensibles: ou à faire parler d'une manière si vague et si indéterminée, que l'on n'exprime rien de distinct. Presque tous ses ouvrages, mais principalement ses huit Livres de Physique ... ne sont qu, une pure Logique.

concepts one can easily explain all things without knowledge of the things themselves.²²

“One becomes no wiser by hearing the Aristotelians say that fire melts metals because it has the faculty of melting, or that someone cannot digest because his stomach has not the faculty, and so on.²³” “But what is the most dangerous thing about these philosophical turns of phrase — quality, faculty, substantiality, and the like — is nevertheless this, that one is thereby ensnared in the imagining that things themselves should contain the true and original causes of the effects we see before our eyes.”

“It is a sinful error; for if there are in things themselves real causes, real faculties to act of themselves, then there is in things something divine, and we come then, just as the heathens, to deify nature.²⁴”

“It is difficult to believe that one ought neither to fear nor to love the real powers, the beings that can act upon us, that can punish us with pain and reward us with joy. And since true worship consists in love and fear, it is furthermore difficult to believe that one ought not to worship them.”

“Everything that can act upon us as a true and real cause is necessarily exalted above us (*est nécessairement au dessus de nous*). When, therefore, God in Holy Scripture proves to the Israelites that they ought to worship him — that is, that they ought to fear and love him — the most important grounds he adduces are drawn from his power to reward them and punish them. He wills that they should honour him, since it is he alone who is the true cause of good and evil; and since, according to the Prophet's word, no evil happens in their city without its being he (Jehovah) who does it.

“The natural causes are therefore by no means real causes of the evil they seem to inflict upon us, since it is God alone who works in them, he alone whom we ought to fear and love: *Soli Deo honor et gloria*.”

If this is not theological, truly theological, then what is theological?

²²S. 386. Aristote est celui qui en a le plus fait usage, tous ses Livres en sont pleins, et il y en a quelques uns, qui ne sont que pure Logique. Il propose et résout toutes choses par ces beaux mots de *genre*, d'*espece*, d'*acte*, de *puissance*, de *nature*, de *forme*, de *facultez*, de *qualitez*, de *cause par soi*, de *cause par accident*. Ses sectateurs ont de la peine à comprendre que ces mots ne signifient rien ...

²³S. 386. Le feu échauffe, sèche, durcit, et amollit, parce qu'il a la faculté de produire ces effets. Le sené purge par sa qualité purgative, le pain même nourrit, si on le veut, par sa qualité nutritive ... Telles ou semblables manières de parler ne sont point fausses, mais c'est qu'en effet elles ne signifient rien.

²⁴S. 387. Que si l'on vient ensuite à considerer attentivement l'idée que l'on a de cause ou de puissance d'agir, on ne peut douter que cette idée ne represente quelque chose de divin. Car l'idée d'une puissance souveraine est l'idée de la souveraine divinité, et l'idée d'une puissance subalterne est l'idée d'une divinité inférieure, mais d'une véritable divinité, au moins, selon la pensée des Payens, supposé que ce soit l'idée d'une puissance ou d'une cause véritable. On admet donc quelque chose de divin dans tous les corps qui nous environnent, lorsqu'on admet des formes des facultez, des qualitez, des vertus, et des êtres réels capables de produire certains effets par la force de leur nature, et l'on entre ainsi insensiblement dans le sentiment des Payens par le respect que l'on a pour leur Philosophie. Il est vrai que la foi nous redresse, mais peut-être que l'on peut dire, que si le coeur est chrétien, le fond de l'esprit est Payen.

“If we assume,” it says further, “the philosophers’ false opinion (cette fausse opinion des Philosophes), namely, that the bodies surrounding us are real causes of the joys and evils we feel, then reason seems to justify a religion like that of the heathens, and to sanction a universal corruption of morals (dérèglement universel des mœurs).”

“Even if reason does not directly tell us that we should therefore straightway worship onions and leeks, it nevertheless advises us to render them a certain veneration in proportion to the benefit they can render us.²⁵”

Inwardly outraged at the falsity in so wretched a philosophy (de la fausseté de cette misérable Philosophie), Malebranche then develops the doctrine: *that there is only one true cause, since there is only one true God; that nature, or the force of things, is nothing other than God’s will; that natural things are not true causes, but solely occasional causes (des causes occasionnelles).*

Here, then, we have the so-called occasionalist system: *systema causarum occasionalium*.

How this theory is really to be understood is made vivid by the following example:

“When one ball collides with another and sets it in motion, it nevertheless communicates nothing; for it does not itself have the impression it communicates. Meanwhile a ball does become a natural cause of the motion it communicates. A natural cause is therefore no true and real cause, but rather an occasional cause, which determines the Creator of nature to act in this or that way in this or that case.²⁶ The laws by which motions are communicated are effective only insofar as God’s will works in them. God has created the world because he willed it: *dixit et facta sunt*. There are therefore in the sensuous world no forces, no powers, no true causes, and one ought not, by ascribing to bodies forms, faculties, and real qualities that they do not have, to deceive oneself and offend the divine majesty.”

²⁵S. 388. Il est vrai que la raison n’enseigne pas qu’il faille adorer les oignons et les porreaux par exemple, comme la souveraine divinité, parce qu’ils ne peuvent nous rendre entièrement heureux, lorsque nous en avons, ou entièrement malheureux lors que nous n’en avons point ... Mais (S. 389), si l’on ne doit pas rendre un honneur souverain aux porreaux et aux oignons, on peut toujours leur rendre quelque adoration particulière: je veux dire, qu’on peut y penser et les aimer en quelque manière, s’il est vrai qu’ils puissent en quelque sorte nous rendre heureux: on doit leur rendre honneur à proportion du bien qu’ils peuvent faire.

²⁶Jvnf. S. 390 med S. 575. Quand je vois une boule qui en choque une autre, mes yeux me disent, ou semblent me dire, qu’elle est véritablement cause du mouvement qu’elle lui imprime: car la véritable cause qui meut les corps ne paroît pas à mes yeux. Mais quand j’interroge ma raison, je vois évidemment que les corps ne pouvant se remuer eux-mêmes, et leur force mouvante n’étant que la volonté de Dieu qui les conserve successivement en différens endroits, ils ne peuvent communiquer une puissance qu’ils n’ont pas, et qu’ils ne pourroient pas mêmes communiquer quand elle seroit en leur disposition. Car il est évident qu’il faut une sagesse, et une sagesse infinie pour régler la communication des mouvemens avec la justesse, la proportion, et l’uniformité que nous voyons.

“God does not need instruments in order to act (Dieu n’a pas besoin d’instruments pour agir); it is only needed that he will it, in order that the thing may be. His power is his will. But to communicate his power to a man or to an angel can mean nothing other than to will that, when a man or an angel wills that this or that body be set in motion, it then moves.” God is therefore, according to the cited example, the true cause of the motion, the angel’s will only an occasional cause.

“To make this still more evident, let us suppose that God willed the opposite of what some spirits, for example the demons, will; then one could nevertheless in this case not say that God communicates to them his power, for they can accomplish nothing of what they wish. Meanwhile these spirits’ wills would nonetheless be natural causes of effects they produced. Such bodies would then move to the right only because these spirits wished that they should move to the left: they thus occasion God to do the opposite of what they will, and their wills thus also become occasional causes.²⁷”

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In the history of theology there is no dogmatician who has held fast to the concept of God’s omnipotence with greater rigour than Malebranche, none who has expressed with greater scientific consistency what lies in the dogma of creation than precisely Malebranche.

He has not, like a Calvin, confined himself to a logical form for a religious language of power; as a philosophical thinker he has everywhere striven to make the truth of faith accessible to reason, and for that reason has not shrunk from engaging with the real phenomena, and giving us an interpretation, consistent with his theory, of the sensuously present order of things.

To be sure, Malebranche has not been able in a speculative way to see into the Father’s primal ground, to discover world-germs in the Son’s Pleroma, and to mediate the process of creation in the plastic power of the Spirit; but the dogma he has, the pure dogma of creation out of nothing. Concerning this dogma he has not merely declared that it must be thought (for because it is now and then said of a dogma that it must be thought, it is

²⁷S. 392. Il n’y a donc qu’un seul vrai Dieu et qu’une seule cause qui soit véritablement cause: et l’on ne doit pas s’imaginer que ce qui précède un effet en soit la véritable cause. Dieu ne peut même communiquer sa puissance aux créatures, si nous suivons les lumières de la raison: il n’en peut faire de véritables causes: il n’en peut faire des dieux. Mais quand il le pourroit, nous ne pouvons concevoir pourquoi il le voudroit. Corps, esprits, pures intelligences, tout cela ne peut rien. C’est celui, qui a fait les esprits, qui les éclaire et qui les agite... Enfin c’est l’Auteur de nôtre être qui exécute nos volontez, semel jussit, semel paret. Il remue même nôtre bras lorsque nous nous en servons contre ses ordres, car il se plaint par ses Prophetes que nous le faisons servir à nos desirs injustes et criminels.

not thereby said that it really gets thought); no, he has in earnest attempted to think it, to hold the thought fast, and to apply it to a scientific understanding of all that is created.

To apply the thought of creation to a scientific understanding of the created is to see the whole world and each single thing in the world under the twofold point of view: *nothing and yet really something!*

The concept in which this contradiction is resolved is the concept: omnipotence; the created is in itself a nothing, but at omnipotence's command it has become something.

He who now looks at what has come to be so one-sidedly that he sees only its nothingness — for him the world is semblance and shadow. Whether theology will call him a pantheist or an acosmist is a matter of indifference; the point is that he denies creation in denying omnipotence.

He who looks at what has come to be so one-sidedly that he sees only its reality, forgets its nothingness, and ascribes to it substantiality — for him coming-to-be is a natural process, and the world a realm of nature. Whether dogmatics must otherwise reckon him among deists, naturalists, or atheists is in this connection a matter of indifference; the point is that he denies creation in denying omnipotence.

He, on the other hand, who in all relations under all lights constantly sees what has come to be from the twofold side: as nothing in itself and yet as really something, he sees in all things God's omnipotence, he thinks, though only in a human way, the thought of creation, he holds fast to the dogma of creation.

This is what Malebranche has done; and in the libraries of theology one will surely have to search long before one finds, as regards this point, a thinker as honestly consistent as he.

Created out of nothing, all existing things are for him in themselves nothing, and continue to be so; created by omnipotence, existing things are for him really present in a real world, which the Creator conserves and governs.

What is matter? The extended, which seems to be something when seen sensuously; but, seen with the eye of reason, matter is essenceless, without form, without faculty, without power to act in any way whatsoever in any direction whatsoever. Nevertheless one cannot, according to the theory, say that matter does not exist; on the contrary! it really exists; for it is created: the earnestness of the almighty will vouches for its existence.

What is the soul? The thinking thing, which in finite thoughts thinks on itself, and imagines itself to be something. But the soul, the finite spirit, is in itself a nothing, a pure nothing, just as inactive, dead, and powerless as matter. Nonetheless the soul really

exists; for it is created, and thus, at omnipotence's command, has become something out of nothing.

As the coming-to-be of created things is a miraculous transition from nothing to something, so too their existence is a miraculous hovering between something and nothing. Corps, esprits, pures intelligences tout cela ne peut rien. C'est celui, qui a fait les esprits, qui les éclaire et qui les agite.

What holds of things themselves holds then also of their mutual relation. This relation cannot possibly be essential, since things themselves are without substantiality. Here there is no interaction between existing things: the natural causes are, after all, not true causes. Nonetheless there is here, in this real world, a real coherence, real laws, a real order of things; even if created things are not true causes, they are yet, for the creating will, existing occasional causes: the divine laws are revelations of the highest reason.²⁸ It has indeed now been supposed that one could go a step further than Malebranche, and improve his doctrine of creation by ascribing to the created some independence after all, some capacity for inner self-development, some faculty for activity; it is then especially Leibniz who has here wished to correct, or rather to push back, the "miracle theory" by inventing the doctrine of monads, devising *harmonia præstabilita*, and asserting *principium rationis sufficientis*.

It is, however, as regards the dogma, a dubious improvement. The created is then, in creation, supposed to have received not merely a real existence, but at the same time an existence in relative independence.

It is now this relative independence that Malebranche could not conceive, and neither, when we look more closely, could a Leibniz. For what is relative independence? A degree of existence outside omnipotence, a self-acting which, however slight it may otherwise be, is nevertheless not omnipotence's acting, and thus: a real limit to omnipotence.

If this real limit is now meant in earnest, then omnipotence is a really limited power, and no longer omnipotence. If, on the other hand, the Almighty still, as before, has the limit within his power, then the real limit is still, as before, a nothing in itself, and the miraculous relation between Creator and creature must continue.

A relation that has begun with a miracle, and been founded by a miracle, must also be continued by an unceasing miracle: not merely for a few moments, not merely, if I may so put it, some 8 to 14 days after the creation; but for centuries, for millennia, in the eternity of eternities, created things must continue to be in themselves what they

²⁸S. 390. Dieu a créé le monde... et produit ainsi tous les effets que nous voyons arriver, parce qu'il a voulu aussi certaines loix, selon lesquelles les mouvemens se communiquent à la rencontre des corps: et parce que ces loix sont efficaces, elles agissent, et les corps ne peuvent agir.

originally are and have been, a nothing, a pure nothing for the Almighty.

It is this consequence that Malebranche holds fast, and therefore he cannot conceive self-activity in any creature whatsoever, be it angel or man, for essential self-activity is a divine matter, and God himself cannot create gods: *il n'en peut faire de véritables causes, il n'en peut faire des Dieux*. The improvement that Leibniz introduces consists now in this, that he lets God create gods²⁹; for his relative monads are indeed like a swarm of little gods. Each of these little gods carries, in the manner of gods, the possibility of a world within itself, is, in the manner of gods, sufficient unto itself, leads, in the manner of gods, an eternal life, and, even if it be weakened at a given time, can nevertheless in all eternity not (unless it were by an extraordinary miracle) lose the faculty of self-development³⁰.

But what is now gained by putting all this self-activity into the created? Two half-thoughts instead of one whole: consistency is broken. On the one hand, creation is still supposed to be meant in earnest — that is, the thought that omnipotence's limit is in itself a nothing. On the other hand, the created's independence is at the same time supposed to be meant in earnest, along with the thought that omnipotence's limit is in itself a something. Omnipotence is thus supposed at one and the same time to be both almighty and yet not almighty; behold, that is what has been gained.

If this, what Leibniz would introduce, even when given a more comprehensible and vulgar form, really is a progress; then indeed it cannot be denied that theology necessarily must have something to say in scientific matters; for now the relation between God and the world becomes as entangled as possible.

Now omnipotence has a limit, and no miracle happens; now omnipotence has no limit, for a miracle has indeed happened. Here there is much to consider, when it — be it noted — is to be considered scientifically. Here is *nihil negativum*, and here is *nihil privativum*; here is *omnipotentia*, here is *præscientia*, here is *providentia*, here is *conservatio*; here is *conservatio rerum simplicium*, here is *annihilatio rerum simplicium*, here is *conservatio nexus cosmici*, here is *destructio nexus cosmici*; and then here is besides *concursus*, and *concursus* again both *universalis* and *specialis* and *specialissimus*.

If there then come to this a multitude of scriptural passages, well exegeted, well cited, well grouped scriptural passages; if these passages are then, in a suitable scheme, accompanied by critical-dogmatic remarks; if these remarks then also give hints that those supernaturalist forms probably do not signify much; if these hints are then so

²⁹Chaque esprit étant comme une petite divinité dans son département. *Monadol.* — Les esprits étants comme de petits Dieux. *Syst. nouv.*

³⁰Atque ideo etiam nulla datur generatio, nec mors perfecta rigore loquendo. Sunt enim evolutiones et accretiones, quas generationes appellamus, quemadmodum involutiones et diminutiones, quod mortem vocamus. *Princip. Philos. Thesis 76.*

plain that everyone must be able to see where the limit is, and where the limit is not, and consequently to discern for himself both what must be thought and what shall be thought, and that here really nothing at all is thought: then we have a tolerably fitting impression, proportionate to the importance of the matter, of the treatment which the concept of nature, smuggled in by “the creature’s self-activity,” undergoes in theology.

By wishing to improve the “miracle theory,” Leibniz loses his scientific bearing, and places himself in the ranks of those who otherwise quack about with *concursum* and *nexus cosmicus* and *destructio nexus cosmi*³¹ and the like; only that he does it with talent and diplomatic suppleness.

For what does it really mean that for everyday use no miracles happen, but only on extraordinary occasions? It means, plainly understood, in plain words: for everyday use God is not almighty; but on extraordinary occasions he is almighty.

That created things are in themselves nothing, and their natural coherence in itself nothing — this thought we human beings cannot endure for everyday use; it comes into force only on isolated extraordinary occasions; in order now not to be overwhelmed by the representation of God’s omnipotence, omniscience, and omnipresence, one must push back the all-too-obtrusive miracle theory, and patch up the reality of things with a little *commercium substantiarum*, *harmonia præstabilita*, a little *nexus cosmicus*, *principium rationis*, and other such mediacies.

“Conservation is a continued creation”; if this thought is really held fast, then Malebranche is right. There can then be no possible difference between creation and conservation other than that which lies in the two concepts: beginning and continuation.

The same Almighty who of old said: Become! must still, in every second, in every moment, keep on saying: Continue to be!

If one nevertheless will now have another and “more thorough” difference between creation and conservation, where do we then get to? Then we arrive at the result that creation is the immediate, conservation the mediate miracle. But in this “thoroughness” there is no sense; for a mediate miracle is a contradiction. *Dieu n’a pas besoin d’instrument pour agir, il suffit qu’il veuille.*

Theology is too inclined to confuse the categories: one-sidedness and consistency. When the thinker now and then seizes one of its own presuppositions, and develops what is essentially contained in it, then at once it is said: what one-sidedness!

Such dismissals are unscientific. In science one whole thought, which really gets thought, is worth more than ten half-thoughts, which on account of their inner incom-

³¹*Omnis autem monas est inextingibilis, neque enim substantiæ simplices nisi creando vel annihilando, id est miraculose oriri aut desinere possunt. Epist. ad Bierlingium.*

patibility never get thought, however much trouble one takes to explain that they “must be thought.”

Malebranche is, with respect to the dogma of creation, not a one-sided but a consistent thinker. Creation is to him in earnest; conservation is therefore also to him in earnest: he does not think *pro forma*! As little as what has come to be could of old create itself, just as little can it even to this day conserve itself; as little as what has come to be could originally be created by another thing that has come to be, just as little can even now the one thing that has come to be be either conserved or moved by the other³².

According to Malebranche, the dogma of creation cannot possibly rest on the contradiction that God, in the beginning of time, should have used his omnipotence to set himself an essential barrier, a barrier that is in itself a something, a barrier that he did not have at every moment absolutely and unconditionally within his power; no, creation is known by this, that God's omnipotence, out of love and with freedom, sets itself an opposite, and through this opposite, at all points, in all directions, at all times, relates itself to itself, to itself alone.

Therefore there is here a real world, and this world's existence is God's work; therefore there is here in the world a real order and effective laws, for this order is God's wisdom, these laws are God's thoughts. Therefore the law and the corresponding occasional causes are meant in earnest — so much in earnest that Malebranche sees God's freedom precisely in this, that the Almighty, who at every moment works every coming-to-be and every motion, binds himself by his own thoughts, his own will, his own laws. *Semel jussit, semel paret. Il remue même notre bras, lorsque nous nous en servons contre ses ordres, car il se plaint par ses Prophetes que nous le faisons servir à nos desirs injustes et criminels.*

The truth in the natural is not nature; the natural is not natural: it is a work of God.

The occasionalist theory carried through can be regarded as a scientific exposition of the Psalmist's words (Ps. 104, 24): *Lord, how manifold are thy works, thou madest them all in wisdom.* We have therefore not done theology an injustice in presenting Malebranche as an example of theological scientificity.

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The *doctrine of creation* carried through in theology is a carried-through *negation of*

³²S. 391. Je dis de plus qu'il n'est pas concevable, que Dieu puisse communiquer aux hommes ou aux Anges la puissance qu'il a de remuer les corps; et que ceux qui prétendent, que le pouvoir que nous avons de remuer nos bras, est une véritable puissance, doivent avouer que Dieu peut aussi donner aux esprits la puissance de créer, d'anéantir, de faire toutes les choses possibles, en un mot, qu'il peut les rendre tout-puissans.

nature.

The theological concept of nature is negative; if this negative concept has scientific validity, then natural science is not merely a very subordinate but also a very dangerous science, for natural science's concept of nature is positive.

What is comprehensible, what is immediately evident, what is unmistakable, what is incontrovertible — of all such we say: "it is natural." That a stone thrown into the air must fall to the earth is natural; that he who holds his finger in the flame must get it burned is natural; that he who falls into the water must get wet, that he who cannot draw breath is suffocated, and so on, is all natural. It must be so; it cannot possibly be otherwise. Why not? Let one give ever so many explanations and adduce ever so many proofs: the nerve in all proofs, the explanatory element in all explanations, is nevertheless the one thing: "yes, it is natural!"

But in all that is natural nothing can be more natural than nature; one must therefore not be surprised that mankind, despite the "higher light" with which theological scientificity has already for centuries shone for the generations, still to this day is so involuntarily caught in the imagining that nature really is, that there is in existence something which, in the natural sense, we must call the essence of nature.

The essence of nature! It would perhaps fall just as naturally to say: nature and essence; for these two concepts are so intimately related that the one must at bottom explain the other. Every grounding in science aims at demonstrating what must necessarily follow from "the essence of the matter," but what follows from "the essence of the matter" is only that which lies in "the nature of the matter."

If now both concepts are at bottom one, and if ground and grounding are decisive for all science; then one cannot be surprised that the human mind still constantly holds fast to the thought that there nevertheless is and must be truth in a science whose whole aim is to know nature in nature's light, although natural science's natural grounds have doubtless come into a highly precarious conflict with theology's "deeper grounds."

If natural science is to count as true science, then one must begin with the presupposition *that there is a natural reciprocal relation between the senses and the sensuous world.*

But if this presupposition is to hold, theology must see to finding itself a place outside science; for its scientificity, as theology, rests precisely on a negation of this presupposition.

He who would know nature must rely on the testimony of the senses. To rely on the testimony of the senses is not the same as to judge objects by the first, casual, immediate

sense-impression. To what extent natural science, in this respect, knows how to make a distinction between semblance and essence, it has surely shown sufficiently, among other things, in its defence of the Copernican system.

To rely on the testimony of the senses means to rely on the inner, essential agreement between the sensuous and that which is sensed, that is: on the natural truth of the sense-impression.

"It is a truth that the senses sense," with this one must begin in natural science; "it is an untruth that the senses sense," with this one must begin in theology.

It is, scientifically understood, not a one-sidedness against a one-sidedness that we have here before us; it is principle against principle, science against science, that is at stake.

By relying on the senses a human being can, even with the best will, never bring it further than to seeing nature in a natural light. The more the senses count, the less faith counts; the less the senses count, the more faith counts.

There is an infinite difference between the trust in the testimony of the senses and of experiences that is demanded in natural science, and the trust in the scientific assistance of the Holy Spirit that the theologians call faith.

If one nevertheless will extend the concept of faith to embrace every assumption resting on inward reliance and trust, one still cannot deny that here there is a difference between faith and faith. The natural scientist's faith is affirmation of nature a priori; the theologian's faith is negation of nature a priori.

In science (it is not forgotten here that it is in science) either the natural faith must annihilate the supernatural, or vice versa.

To wish to see nature at once *both* in a natural and yet supernatural light, *both* in a holy and yet scientific light — this willing-of-both is no sign of speculative profundity, but a sign of thoughtlessness; for it is a contradiction.

If the natural light is to shine, the supernatural must be extinguished; if the holy light is to rise, the scientific must be extinguished.

C'est pour nous accommoder à la manière ordinaire de parler, que nous dirons dans la suite, que les sens sentent; with these words Malebranche extinguishes the natural light; the pious thinker "beholds all things in God": fides præcedit intellectum.

If theology now really has such trust in its fides præcedit intellectum that with it, in our days, it dares in earnest to defy natural science; then we shall not merely concede that it has a faith, but even willingly grant that its faith goes far in advance of its understanding.

If natural science is to be regarded as true science, then the principle must be held fast *that the natural understanding is in truth able to know the laws of nature*.

But if this principle is to hold in science, theology doubtless does best to seek itself a place outside science; for it is a principle that faith must deny.

If faith is to judge, then the laws of existence are God's thoughts, his will the only true cause. Il n'y a donc qu'un seul vrai Dieu et qu'une seule cause, qui soit véritablement cause.

If the understanding is to judge, then the laws of existence are grounded in the essence of things, and there must consequently be just as many true causes as there are natural forces.

If faith is to judge, the laws of things must be capable of alteration at whatever moment it pleases God; if the understanding is to judge, even the smallest deviation from the law must be assumed to conflict with "the nature of the matter."

Here judgment goes against judgment, and the essence of nature is at stake. When the one judgment is heard, the other cannot be heard; one cannot at one time hear two judgments because one has two ears.

The ear of faith cannot at all hear the judgment of the understanding, as little as the ear of the understanding can hear the judgment of faith. The judgment of faith is heard in the "Oratory," but the judgment of the understanding must be heard in the "Laboratory." To place oneself midway between the "Oratory" and the "Laboratory," prick up both ears, and say: *credo, ut intelligam*, in order to listen to both sides, is to give oneself une fausse position.

If the judgment of the understanding is to be heard in science, the judgment of faith must be heard outside science; one cannot reconcile such contradictory judgments in one scientific judgment.

In order to conceal the glaring contradiction, one has attempted a humane accommodation.

"The laws of nature are certainly God's thoughts; but God cannot, after all, alter these thoughts, since it conflicts with his immutability."

So runs the humane accommodation; but the truth presses on: the heterogeneous will be separated.

It goes with humane accommodation for a time, as with Jesuitical torture for a time; suddenly comes — the moment! Spirits grow wroth, principles are incensed: Luther is coarse, Galileo stamps on the floor.

If natural science is to be regarded as a science, then the idea of reason holds *that*

the realm of nature is a whole closed within itself, whose heterogeneous fundamental parts, according to their qualities, are combined and separated in such a way that the whole's particular members are formed, shaped, and dissolved with inner necessity.

But if this idea of reason is to hold in science, theology does best to move out of science; for it lies precisely in its supernaturalist character to deny this idea.

“Ground,” “primal ground,” “becoming,” “birth,” “inner forming,” “involuntary expression of one’s own disposition,”³³ “instinct” and “impulse,” are the categories that hover before consciousness when the talk is of maternal nature.

That there is a truth in this, theology too acknowledged in its own way, when it really began to speculate over the paternal nature.

In the doctrine of the Son’s eternal birth from the Father, Athanasius was after all proved right against Arius, and why? Because reason, on this point, was allowed to discern that, if the Son was in unity of essence (ὁμοούσιος) with the Father, then he could not have been created with freedom, but must have been born of necessity.

But, in that theology thereby gained an insight into the essence of nature, its scientific progress consisted really in this, that it transferred categories from the natural to the supernatural. In its striving to comprehend the supernatural nature (θεία φύσις) it thus barred its own way to an understanding of the natural nature. The Son’s nature is born, but not created; Adam’s nature is created, but not born; Adam’s children, on the other hand, are both created and born: can anything scientific come out of this?

God cannot create gods, therefore the Son is born from eternity; that is what Athanasius has discerned.

God cannot create gods, therefore there is no nature in the created; that is what Malebranche has discerned.

What is in truth to become a nature must come to be in a natural way; what has come to be by a miracle must have a miraculous existence, and can never become anything in truth natural, just as little as it can ever become a natural true cause of anything else natural. “In the natural relations of nature there is just as little truth as in natural nature”; this is the theological-scientific consequence of the dogma of creation.

If Adam is created, then Adam is no nature, then there is no nature in Adam. If there is no nature in Adam, then there is likewise no nature in Eve. If there is no nature in Adam and Eve, then Adam and Eve’s children likewise cannot be born; they must all be

³³“Unsere Erklärung von dem Natürlichen,” says Link (Propyläen der Naturgeschichte. Berlin 1839, S. 4) “ist dieselbe, welche Aristoteles giebt,” and cites on this occasion Physic. lib. 2, c. 1.

Τὰ μὲν γὰρ φύσει ὄντα πάντα φαίνεται ἔχοντα ἐν ἑαυτοῖς ἀρχὴν κινήσεως καὶ στάσεως, τὰ μὲν κατὰ τὸπον, τὰ δὲ κατ’ αὐξησιν καὶ φθίσιν, τὰ δὲ κατ’ ἀλλοίωσιν.

created. In this sense one can then say with truth that every human being is a creature of God.

Human nature, human birth, all such is, according to Malebranche, just as surely semblance and sense-deception as it is semblance and sense-deception that the one body should really be able to set the other in motion.

That a human being can be born can be thought; it is a pure, natural matter, and there is to that extent unity in the thought. That a human being can be created can be thought; it is a pure, supernatural matter, and there is to that extent unity in the thought. But that a human being should be able *both* to be born and to be created, *both* to be created and to be born — this both-and cannot be thought, for it is a contradiction.

If “creationism” and “traducianism” really let themselves be mediated by *credo*, *ut intelligam*, then circle and conscience probably also let themselves be mediated by *credo*, *ut intelligam*. A “birth-process” that is at the same time “a creation-process,” a birth-creation, a creation-birth, a traducian creationism, a creationist traducianism, a natural miracle-process, a miraculous nature-process: if this is scientific, then natural science is unscientific.

Everyone who knows what science is must really admit that the theology of our day finds itself in a peculiar position. In the same degree that it approaches the supernatural, it must distance itself from nature; in the same degree that it will approach a knowledge of nature, it must deny the supernatural.

Admonished, especially by Kant, the theologians for a time proceeded according to the principle that everything depended on holding to the law of nature and to practical reason.

“If only we could, in a scientific way, get rid of the many unreasonable miracles!” thought the Rationalists, and so they began to explain away the many “unreasonable” miracles. It succeeded, even beyond expectation; one miracle disappeared after another — in a scientific way. At last only one miracle remained, namely creation; this miracle one might indeed reinterpret in particulars, but on the whole not explain away; for the miracle of creation was after all at bottom a quite reasonable miracle. By this reasonable procedure theology became undeniably more and more reasonable, more and more scientific; at last only one thing was lacking: consistency.

In science a consequence may sometimes keep one waiting, but never fail to come. The Straussian critique was Rationalism’s consequence; the consequence took away the last remnant of the last miracle, and theology went backward out of science.

Chastened by the scourge of criticism, theology has again, little by little, begun with

credo, ut intelligam, to turn toward the supernatural; we cannot but take note of its conversion. But a true conversion also has its consequence: “show me thy faith by thy works!”

If theology really makes it its earnest to turn toward the supernatural, and carries through the consequence of conversion; then it shall never more dread the miracle, never more bow to a law of nature.

If theology really makes it its earnest to turn toward the supernatural, and carries through the consequence of conversion; then its powers will grow, then it will become strong: strong in Credo, strong in Intelligam, strong in the miracle! so strong in the miracle that its miracle-strength strikes “all-nature” dead, and goes victorious — out of science.

If theology really makes it its earnest to turn toward the supernatural, and carries through the consequence of conversion, then it obtains peace from all criticism; then it is gathered to its fathers, and lands in a better harbour: Athanasius has long since prepared it a place; Malebranche stands waiting in the “Oratory.”

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Between theology and natural science there is no understanding: theology's concept of nature is not natural, and natural science's is not theological.

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